China Digital Survival Kit

Everything a first-timer needs to land, pay, navigate, and stay connected in China — without panic.



Made by Kat · Tested on the ground in China

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Welcome: Read this first

This is not a generic travel guide. It's a step-by-step operational manual for first-time visitors to China.

China is not difficult — but it is different. Payments are QR-code based, Google and WhatsApp don't work, and your credit card will sit unused in your wallet. If you set up the right apps and habits before you land, your trip becomes effortless. If you don't, you'll spend your first day panicking outside a dumpling shop that only accepts Alipay.

I made this checklist after walking dozens of friends through their first China trips. Tick off each section, screenshot the emergency numbers, and keep this PDF on your phone offline.

Let's get you China-ready.

KAT'S TIP

Do not wait until you land to download VPNs or payment apps. The App Store and Google Play inside China are filtered.

Ready? China!

01

Passport & Visa

Check your passport expiry date now. China requires at least 6 months of validity beyond your travel dates, plus blank pages for stamps.

No passport yet? Start the application immediately — it can take 4–6 weeks in many countries.

Visa rules change by nationality.

Many Western passports (UK, Australia, Canada, Germany, France, Italy, Spain, Netherlands, Sweden, Switzerland, New Zealand, Japan, South Korea, Malaysia, Thailand, Singapore, Brazil, Russia) currently receive 30-day visa-free entry through December 31, 2026.

US, Indian, Vietnamese, Pakistani, South African and some other passport holders still need an L (Tourist) visa. Apply through the official China Visa Application Service Centre.

144-hour visa-free transit is available for many nationalities if you have an onward ticket to a third country. Valid in Beijing, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Chengdu and more.

KAT'S TIP

Always verify the latest policy with your nearest Chinese embassy before booking. Visa-free extensions have been repeatedly renewed.

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02

Flights & Hotels

Booking flights:

- Trip.com — best for China domestic routes, accepts foreign cards.
- Google Flights — best for comparing international prices.
- Air China, China Eastern, China Southern — often cheapest direct.
- Tuesdays and Wednesdays usually have lower fares on China routes.
- Avoid Golden Week (Oct 1–7) and Chinese New Year — prices triple.

Booking hotels:

- Not all hotels in China accept foreign guests. International chains (IHG, Marriott, Hilton, Accor) are always safe.
- Booking.com — most reliable for foreigners, free cancellation.
- Trip.com — 10–20% cheaper for local boutique hotels.
- Save your hotel address in Chinese on your phone.
- Book refundable rooms until your visa is confirmed.

KAT'S TIP

screenshot your hotel name and address in Chinese before you land. Taxi drivers rarely read English.

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03

SIM or eSIM

You need data the moment you land. There are four options:

eSIM — best for most travelers

- Buy before you fly on Nomad, Airalo, Holafly or China Unicom International.
- Activate by scanning a QR code. Works the moment you land.
- Around ¥100 ($13 USD) for 10GB / 30 days.
- Check compatibility: dial *#06# — if you see EID, you're good.

Physical Chinese SIM — best for 2+ weeks

- Buy at China Mobile / Unicom / Telecom airport counters. Bring your passport — it's required by law to register.
- Around ¥250 ($35 USD) for 80GB + 300 minutes / 30 days.

Pocket WiFi — best backup or groups

- Rent at the airport or pre-book online.
- Around $4 USD/day. Less ideal for solo travelers moving between cities.

KAT'S TIP

My honest pick: if your phone supports eSIM, grab one before you fly. Staying longer? Get a China Mobile SIM at the airport for best nationwide coverage.

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04

Payments: Alipay, WeChat & QR

China is almost entirely cashless. Street food stalls, taxis, supermarkets — everything runs on QR codes.

Alipay — do this first

- Download the International version.
- Verify your identity and link a foreign Visa, Mastercard or Amex.
- No Chinese bank account needed.
- Used absolutely everywhere.

WeChat Pay — great backup

- Built into WeChat.
- Also accepts foreign cards. Also unlocks restaurant menus, mini-programs and messaging.

Cash backup

- Bring ¥300–500 RMB as backup for internet issues.
- Refusing RMB cash is illegal in China.

How QR payment works

- You scan the vendor's QR → enter amount → confirm.
- Or vendor scans your QR from your Receive screen.
- The #1 mistake: using your phone's camera instead of the scan inside Alipay/WeChat.

KAT'S TIP

Restaurant tables often have a QR. Scan it with WeChat to see the menu, order and pay — all without speaking Mandarin.

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The Firewall & VPN

China runs a national internet filter called the Great Firewall. Google, Gmail, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, WhatsApp, Twitter/X, Snapchat, Spotify and ChatGPT are blocked.

The one rule: download and test your VPN before you fly. Once in China, app stores are filtered and you can't easily download a new VPN.

Free VPNs almost never work reliably. Invest in a paid one with a proven China track record.

What works without a VPN:

- Amap (navigation)
- Dianping (restaurant reviews)
- Didi (rides)
- WeChat and Alipay

VPN use by tourists is a grey area. Millions of visitors use them every year for personal communication without issues.

KAT'S TIP

Download Amap before arrival. Google Maps won't work reliably in China.

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06

Your Essential App Starter Pack

Download these 6 apps before you fly. They will run your entire trip:

WeChat — messaging, payments, menus, mini-programs.
Alipay — pay for everything.
Didi — China's Uber, works in English.
Amap — accurate navigation, English mode, offline maps.
Dianping — restaurant ratings and reviews.
Trip.com — trains, flights, hotels in English with foreign cards.

Translation: download Google Translate with the Chinese offline pack. Baidu Translate is a solid local alternative.

Set these up at home. Some need verification that's much easier to complete before you arrive.

KAT'S TIP

Add a Chinese-speaking friend on WeChat if you have one. They can rescue you in almost any situation.

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Getting Around Like a Local

At the airport: ignore anyone in arrivals offering a 'taxi.' Use Didi or the airport metro.

High-speed rail ():

- The backbone of China travel — fast, cheap, punctual.
- Beijing → Shanghai: 4.5 hours, ~¥550 second class.
- Book with your passport on Trip.com or the 12306 app.
- G trains = fastest, D = slightly slower, C = city rail.

Metro:

- Buy a single ticket at the machine (English available) or scan Alipay/WeChat at the gate.
- Fares: ¥3–15 per journey.
- Rush hours: 7:30–9am and 5:30–7pm.

Didi:

- Pin your exact pickup location.
- Message the driver: 'I'm a foreigner and don't speak Chinese.' (I'm a foreigner, I don't speak Chinese).
- Most city rides: ¥20–40.

Shared bikes: Meituan and Hellobike. Scan with Alipay/WeChat. ¥1–3 per 30 minutes. Park in designated zones.

KAT'S TIP

You can order food delivery directly to your train seat by scanning the QR code on the seat back.

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Emergency Numbers & Help

Screenshot this page and save it in your phone.

110 — Police (theft, attack, threats). SMS 12110 if you can't speak Mandarin.
120 — Ambulance. A single trip can cost $55 USD without insurance.
119 — Fire.
122 — Traffic accident in the city. Expressway: 12122.
12308 — Foreign Affairs hotline. Lost passport, detention, consular support.
12367 — Visa & immigration questions.

Beijing, Shanghai and Chengdu all have international hospitals with English-speaking staff.

Lost passport? Contact your embassy and the local police. The police report is required for a replacement travel document.

KAT'S TIP

If you have a Chinese number, you can send an emergency SMS to 12110 when calling 110 is difficult.

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Travel Insurance

This is the step most travelers skip — and later regret.

Real numbers from Beijing hospitals:

- Outpatient visit without insurance: ¥5,000–50,000 ($700–7,000 USD).
- Ambulance ride: ¥400–800.
- Medical evacuation: up to $100,000 USD.
- Travel insurance cost: about $3–8 per day.

What to look for:

- Medical coverage of at least $100,000 USD.
- Emergency evacuation included.
- Trip cancellation / interruption coverage.
- Lost baggage and passport replacement.
- 24/7 emergency assistance hotline.

Recommended providers: World Nomads, SafetyWing, Allianz Travel. Check if your credit card already includes travel insurance.

KAT'S TIP

Screenshot or print your policy number and emergency hotline before you leave.

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Arrival & Immigration

On the plane:

- Fill in your Arrival Card — or do it online up to 3 days before landing.
- Have your hotel address (in Chinese) and phone number ready.
- Have your return or onward ticket accessible.

At immigration:

- Join the Foreigners queue (Foreigners lane).
- They'll take fingerprints and a photo — routine.
- Have ready: passport, Arrival Card, hotel booking confirmation.
- If asked your purpose: 'Tourism' (tourism, tourism).

Customs:

- Most travelers use the green Nothing to Declare channel.
- You can bring up to ¥5,000 RMB cash without declaring.
- Don't bring fresh fruit, meat or dairy.
- Power banks need a CCC certification mark.

KAT'S TIP

Keep your boarding pass until you've confirmed your bag arrived at baggage claim.

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Quick-Reference Card

Emergency Numbers

110 Police
120 Ambulance
119 Fire
122 Traffic accident
12122 Expressway accident
12308 Foreign Affairs
12367 Visa & immigration

Apps to Download

WeChat
Alipay
Didi
Amap
Dianping
Trip.com
Google Translate (offline Chinese)

Pre-Flight Checklist

- □ Passport valid 6+ months
- □ Visa confirmed or visa-free eligibility checked
- □ eSIM/SIM purchased or planned
- □ Alipay or WeChat Pay set up and tested
- □ VPN downloaded and tested
- □ Amap, Didi, WeChat downloaded
- □ Travel insurance purchased
- □ Hotel address saved in Chinese
- □ ¥300–500 cash backup
- □ Emergency numbers screenshot saved

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Keep this PDF on your phone offline. Screenshot the emergency numbers. You've got this — and if you don't, message Kat at readychinatravel.com.